[…] ‘Clearly, what the Tatas are witnessing today is not just a transfer of power from one generation to another. It’s also a new energy and a more aggressive style. And these should make the Tatas unassailable as India’s premier business house.’

Interestingly, the last sentence turned out to be prescient and the group’s position at the top in India remains undisturbed.

Ratan’s role in reforming the group soon gained recognition. On 19 January 1985, a leading newspaper published a report that Ratan was adjudged the most respected chief executive in Indian industry. It quoted a poll by Marketing and Research Group (MRG), published in a business magazine. In the assessment, based on eight attributes, Ratan scored 6.8 points on a 10-point scale, while Russi Mody scored 6.6 points and Hindustan Lever Chairman A.S. Ganguly, Dhirubhai Ambani and H.P. Nanda tied for third position, scoring 6.5 points each.

This was evidence that the views of the Tata Group veterans, who had virtually dismissed Ratan as a greenhorn, were not shared by the press and the business community. More significantly, it was a foretelling of the transformation that the largest industrial house in India would undertake if Ratan became its helmsman.